Is That Date Firm?

Questions to ask the discharge planner, the doctor and the pharmacist before your husband's next care decision.

Someone at the hospital mentioned Friday. The rehab said they need to hear from you. Neither of them said whether that was a deadline. The person who said it can tell you, so bring these questions written down, ask them as they are, and write the answer under each one.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. That depends on your husband's situation, and the people below are the ones who know it.

The discharge planner or social worker

Whoever at the hospital is arranging what comes after his stay. Some hospitals have a discharge planner; it may also be a social worker or a nurse.

1. Is the discharge date we were given firm, and who set it?

2. What does the family need to decide before that date, and what can be decided after it?

3. Who is responsible for arranging each thing that has to be in place when he leaves: the hospital, the rehab or us?

4. Can we have the dates and instructions you've given us in writing?

5. Who do we call if we have a question about the date or the plan?

The rehab, or anyone else waiting for an answer from you

1. What exactly are you asking us to decide?

2. Is there a date you need our answer by, and who set it?

3. What do you need from us, or from his doctor, before we answer?

The doctor

1. What do you still need to find out before the next decision about his care can be made?

2. Here is our list of open questions. Which are yours to answer, and who should the others go to?

3. Is there anything on our list you'd want to review before we act on it?

The pharmacist

1. The pharmacy asked us some questions. Which can the family answer, and which should go to his prescriber?

2. Is anything waiting on those answers, and is there a date attached to it?

A care consultant

Someone who looks at your husband's whole situation with the family, not only the decision in front of you this week.

1. Looking at our list of decisions and open questions, what else would you want to know before they're put in order?

2. Which other professionals would you want involved, and who should ask them?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, say which one matters most, or tell you what order to decide things in. If one of them feels pressing to you, say so to the person you're asking.

Ready for the next step?

You know which question goes to which person, and soon you'll have some answers. The care interview gives those answers somewhere to go: it walks you through your husband's situation area by area and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The questions about getting things in writing and whom to call follow what Medicare's discharge checklist and the Family Caregiver Alliance's discharge planning guide tell families to ask. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's working list for this step. The grouping by role is ours.

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers

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